Introduction

> *If in 10 or 15 years—or sooner, but 10 or 15 years—China begins to act aggressively externally and in a hostile way, these two countries [India and the US] will come together naturally. So they do not have to plan for it; they'll come together.… So they don't have to plan for it; it will happen, it seems to me, because they are natural allies.*
>
> —Robert Blackwill,
> former US ambassador to India, 2006[1]

> *Engagement with the United States is essential in the world that we live in.… This is not an alliance against any other country. … We are not part of any military alliance and we are not ganging up against any other country, least of all against China.… I wish to dispel this opinion which may exist that what we have done with the United States is at the cost of China or any other country.*
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> —Manmohan Singh, prime minister of India, 2005[2]

On January 25, 2015, at 9:38 a.m., US president Barack Obama stepped off *Air Force One* onto the tarmac at Delhi's Palam airport. Departing from protocol, Indian prime minister Narendra Modi was there to receive him. While the sky overhead was gloomy, the state of US-India relations was not. Visible signs of how much the relationship had deepened over the previous decade and a half were everywhere, from the two leaders' embrace on the tarmac to the reason for Obama's visit—the first American president to be invited to be chief guest at India's annual Republic Day celebrations—to the American strategic airlift and maritime reconnaissance aircraft